

# The Clock [3600, 60, 1]: A Different Diophantine Structure

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*A Didactic Comparison and Structural Analysis*

Bilal El Issaoui, Amsterdam, 2026

## ABSTRACT

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This paper compares two number system architectures: the (25, 12) system, an engineered Diophantine representation system, and the clock [3600, 60, 1], the canonical sexagesimal positional system. Both are linear Diophantine representations and both use modular arithmetic, but they achieve their structure through opposite mechanisms and serve fundamentally different purposes.

The (25, 12) system is designed so that its coefficients satisfy a single foundation relation,  $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ . This makes the smallest coefficient directly computable as  $A_0 = N \bmod 12$ . Nothing bounds the coefficients, so the system accepts a whole ladder of valid representations for the same  $N$ .

The clock rests on a different Diophantine mechanism. Its bases form a hierarchical divisibility chain,  $3600 \rightarrow 60 \rightarrow 1$ , where each position value is an exact multiple of the one below it. On top of that, each coefficient is bounded by the ratio of the adjacent bases: seconds and minutes stay below 60, hours stay below 24. Together, the divisibility chain and the bounds give exactly one (H, M, S) triple per time value  $T$ . Remove either property, and uniqueness collapses.

We show that the clock's coefficients (3600, 60, 1) are not a failed attempt at Diophantine structure. They are the correct design for a positional Diophantine system whose purpose is universal uniqueness. Transitions are governed by carry and overflow within a bounded chain, not by residue relations across unbounded coefficients. The 12-hour cycle metaphor shares the modular principle with the (25, 12) system. The structural system [3600, 60, 1] arrives at its uniqueness through a different mechanism. This distinction is essential for understanding why engineered Diophantine systems and canonical positional Diophantine systems serve structurally incomparable purposes.

# 1 PURPOSE: DESIGNED OPTIMIZATION VERSUS UNIVERSAL UNIQUENESS

*Why read this: before going into the mathematics, it matters to know that both systems serve a different purpose. Without that distinction, the difference in structure would seem arbitrary.*

| Property                  | (25, 12) system                                                                                    | Clock [3600, 60, 1]                                                                              |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Origin                    | Engineered: coefficients chosen so that the foundation relation holds                              | Pre-existing, ancient (Babylonian sexagesimal)                                                   |
| Purpose                   | Minimal and optimal representation counting and generation                                         | One unique time indication per moment                                                            |
| Degree of freedom         | Multiple (A, B) pairs possible per N                                                               | Exactly one (H, M, S) triple per T                                                               |
| System type               | Linear Diophantine representation system with unbounded coefficients and a single residue relation | Linear Diophantine representation system with bounded coefficients and hierarchical divisibility |
| Number of representations | Variable: $R(N) \geq 0$ ; some N have multiple                                                     | Exactly one for every T within domain                                                            |
| Frobenius boundary        | 263 (largest non-representable number)                                                             | None; every T is representable                                                                   |
| Ladder structure          | Yes: $A = A_0 + 12 \cdot k$ , $B = B_0 - 25 \cdot k$                                               | No; no multiple solutions                                                                        |

**Core message:** both systems are Diophantine. Both solve a linear equation with integer coefficients. The (25, 12) system is designed so that a single residue relation makes the smallest coefficient directly readable, and it leaves the coefficients unbounded so that a whole family of solutions exists. The clock is designed so that a hierarchical divisibility chain makes each layer readable in sequence, and it bounds each coefficient so that only one solution exists. Different purposes, different Diophantine mechanisms.

## 2 THE MOD OPERATION: GLOBAL SINGLE VERSUS LOCAL CASCADING

*Why read this: this is the technical core of the paper. The difference between one global mod step and a chain of local mod steps explains almost everything that follows.*

### 2.1 (25, 12) system: One Global Operation

Foundation relation ( $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ ):

$$A_0 = N \pmod{c_2}$$

This is one global operation on the original number  $N$ . Because  $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ ,  $B$  vanishes completely from the equation modulo  $c_2$ :

$$N = c_1 \cdot A + c_2 \cdot B \equiv 1 \cdot A + 0 \cdot B \equiv A \pmod{c_2}$$

### 2.2 Clock: A Chain of Local Moduli

Clock decomposition:

$$S = T \pmod{60}$$

$$M = \text{floor}((T \pmod{3600}) / 60)$$

$$H = \text{floor}(T / 3600) \pmod{24}$$

Here there is no global modulus. Each layer has its own modulus (60, 60, 24), and the mod step always operates on the remainder from the previous layer, not directly on  $T$ .

This is what is meant by cascade modularity: a chain of mod and div pairs, no single congruence that decomposes the entire number in one blow.

## 2.3 The Concrete Difference in One Sentence

|                     | (25, 12) system                                                             | Clock                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Scope of mod        | Global: $A_0 = N \bmod c_2$ for every $N$ , a property of the entire number | Local: $S = T \bmod 60$ only for the seconds layer; says nothing about $H$ or $M$ without first dividing away higher layers |
| Analogue of $A_0$ ? | Yes: $A_0$ captures in one step the full structure of $N$ modulo $c_2$      | No: there is no single number that captures in one step the full $(H, M, S)$ structure of $T$                               |
| Role of mod         | Structural decomposer: determines the entire system                         | Isolation mechanism: separates one layer from the rest                                                                      |

### 3 WHY FOUNDATION DOES NOT HOLD FOR THE CLOCK, AND NEED NOT HOLD

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*Why read this: this section shows that the clock is not a failed Diophantine system. It is a Diophantine system built on a different mechanism. Not having Foundation is a feature here, not a shortcoming.*

Foundation requires  $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ .

For the clock:  $3600 \bmod 60 = 0$ , not 1.

This is not a design flaw. It is precisely what you need for a positional Diophantine system whose coefficients are bounded.

$60^2 = 3600$  is divisible by 60, and 60 is divisible by 1.

This guarantees that there is no overlap or ambiguity between positions. That is the opposite purpose of Foundation, which is designed to explicitly structure multiple representations (the ladder  $A_0, A_0 + 12, A_0 + 24, \dots$ ).

#### **Fact 3.1 (Two Different Diophantine Mechanisms).**

- Foundation ( $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ ) with unbounded coefficients: multiple representations possible (ladder).
- Positional divisibility ( $g^k$  divisible by  $g^{k-1}$ ) with bounded coefficients: exactly one representation.

Both mechanisms are Diophantine. Both produce a deterministic structure. They produce opposite outcomes because they impose opposite constraints: one forbids bounds, the other requires them. The clock consciously chooses the latter.

## 4 THE $13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ CONNECTION: METAPHOR VERSUS STRUCTURE

*Why read this: this prevents a common mistake, namely thinking that the 12-hour clock metaphor is the same as the clock structure  $[3600, 60, 1]$ . It is not.*

The clock as metaphor (the 12-hour dial) illustrates cyclic reduction:

$$13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12} \leftrightarrow 13:00 = 1:00 \text{ PM}$$

This is the same modular thought as  $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$  in the  $(25, 12)$  system. But:

| Property             | Clock metaphor<br>(12-hour cycle)    | Clock structure<br>$[3600, 60, 1]$                     | $(25, 12)$ system                                                        |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Principle            | $13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$              | $60 \equiv 0 \pmod{12}$ ,<br>$3600 \equiv 0 \pmod{12}$ | $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$                                                  |
| Modular contribution | Only hours count modulo 12           | Only seconds count modulo 12 ( $S = T \pmod{12}$ )     | Coefficient A carries all modular information ( $N \equiv A \pmod{12}$ ) |
| Representation       | Multiple hours for same mod 12 class | Exactly one (H, M, S) per T                            | Multiple (A, B) pairs per N                                              |

**Important distinction:** the metaphor ( $13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ ) shares the modular principle with the  $(25, 12)$  system. The structure  $[3600, 60, 1]$  arrives at its uniqueness by a different mechanism. The shared element is mod as an isolation mechanism, not  $N \bmod q$  as a global, ladder-generating congruence.

## 5 COMPARISON OF THE ENGINE

*Why read this: here you see concretely why the (25, 12) system answers in a single step, while the clock answers step by step. Both have an engine. They are different engines.*

### 5.1 The Engine of the (25, 12) System

The (25, 12) system rests on the non-trivial congruence  $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ . This property makes  $c_1$  the engine of the system:

$$N = 25 \cdot A + 12 \cdot B \Rightarrow N \equiv A \pmod{12}$$

Since  $12 \cdot B \equiv 0 \pmod{12}$  and  $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ ,  $B$  vanishes completely from the equation modulo 12. The smallest coefficient  $A_0 = N \bmod 12$  is therefore directly determined in one step.

**Theorem 5.1 (Direct Determinability of  $A_0$ ).** For all  $N \geq 264$ , the smallest non-negative  $A$  for which  $N = 25 \cdot A + 12 \cdot B$  has a non-negative solution is  $A_0 = N \bmod 12$ . This follows from the foundation relation with  $c_1 = 25$  and  $c_2 = 12$ :  $(c_1 - 1)(c_2 - 1) = 24 \cdot 11 = 264$ , exactly one more than the Frobenius boundary 263.

### 5.2 The Engine of the Clock

The clock also has an engine. It is not a single residue relation, but a hierarchical divisibility chain combined with coefficient bounds. Transitions between positions proceed via carry and overflow inside that chain:

- Seconds:  $S = T \bmod 60$ ; when  $S \geq 60$ , carry propagates to minutes.
- Minutes:  $M = \text{floor}(T / 60) \bmod 60$ ; when  $M \geq 60$ , carry propagates to hours.
- Hours:  $H = \text{floor}(T / 3600) \bmod 24$ ; when  $H \geq 24$ , carry propagates to days.

**Fact 5.2 (Cascade Modularity).** The clock uses a cascaded modular system where each position has its own modulus (60, 60, 24), and each position value is an exact multiple of the one below. Together with the bounds on each coefficient, this chain is what makes the decomposition unique. The (25, 12) system instead uses a single modulus (12) and relies on a residue relation to make its smallest coefficient directly readable, while leaving its coefficients unbounded.

Both are Diophantine engines. One is driven by a residue relation, the other by exact divisibility plus bounds. They answer different questions and produce opposite outcomes on purpose.

## 6 FORMULA SUMMARY

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### 6.1 Clock System (Canonical Positional Diophantine)

**Definition 6.1 (Clock Representation).** For every  $T$  with  $0 \leq T \leq 86399$ , the unique solution is:

$$T = 3600 \cdot H + 60 \cdot M + S$$

with:

$$H = \text{floor}(T / 3600) \bmod 24$$

$$M = \text{floor}((T \bmod 3600) / 60)$$

$$S = T \bmod 60$$

### 6.2 (25, 12) System (Diophantine, Unbounded)

**Definition 6.2 ((25, 12) Representation).** For  $N$  a natural number:

$$N = 25 \cdot A + 12 \cdot B, \text{ with } A, B \geq 0$$

Smallest coefficient:

$$A_0 = N \bmod 12$$

Number of representations:

$$R(N) = \text{floor}((\text{floor}(N / 25) - A_0) / 12) + 1, \text{ if } \text{floor}(N / 25) \geq A_0; \text{ else } R(N) = 0$$

And the complete ladder:

$$A_k = A_0 + 12 \cdot k, B_k = (N - 25 \cdot A_k) / 12 \text{ for } k = 0, 1, \dots, k_{\max}.$$

## 7 STRUCTURE COMPARISON TABLE

| Property                             | (25, 12) system                                               | Clock [3600, 60, 1]                                                             |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| System type                          | Linear Diophantine, unbounded coefficients                    | Linear Diophantine, bounded coefficients                                        |
| Structural condition                 | $p \equiv 1 \pmod{q}$ , i.e. $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$          | $g^k$ divisible by $g^{k-1}$ , i.e. $3600 \mid 60 \mid 1$                       |
| Ratio of successive coefficients     | $25 / 12 \approx 2.083$ (non-integer)                         | 60 (constant, integer)                                                          |
| Number of representations per N or T | Variable: $R(N) \geq 0$ ; some N have multiple                | Exactly one for every T within domain                                           |
| Modular property                     | $N \equiv A \pmod{12}$ ; coefficient A is directly determined | $T \equiv S \pmod{60}$ ; only lowest position counts in isolation               |
| Frobenius boundary                   | 263 (largest non-representable number)                        | None; every T is representable                                                  |
| Ladder structure                     | Yes: $A = A_0 + 12 \cdot k$ , $B = B_0 - 25 \cdot k$          | No; no multiple solutions                                                       |
| Cyclic group structure               | $\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}$ via residue $r = N \bmod 12$        | $\mathbb{Z}/60\mathbb{Z}$ (minutes, seconds), $\mathbb{Z}/24\mathbb{Z}$ (hours) |

## 8 COMMON GROUND AND FUNDAMENTAL DIFFERENCES

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### 8.1 What They Share

Both are linear Diophantine representations with a fixed coefficient set that decomposes  $N$  or  $T$  into sublayers. Both use modular arithmetic as an isolation mechanism for one layer. Both can be illustrated with the cyclic reduction metaphor ( $13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$  for the 12-hour dial), but that is a property of the metaphor, not of the structure  $[3600, 60, 1]$  itself.

## 8.2 Where They Fundamentally Differ

| (25, 12) architecture                                                                       | Clock architecture                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Designed to realize the foundation and chain conditions for optimal representation counting | Exposes a universal, pre-existing positional structure serving a different purpose (uniqueness)    |
| Coefficients are design variables, chosen to guarantee desired properties                   | Coefficients are given, fixed by historical convention (Babylonian sexagesimal)                    |
| Multiple representations are desired and structured (ladder)                                | Multiple representations are undesired and excluded (carry and overflow inside a bounded chain)    |
| Mod is global and structural: determines the entire system                                  | Mod is local and functional: isolates one layer                                                    |
| Coefficients are unbounded                                                                  | Coefficients are bounded by the ratio of adjacent bases (60 for seconds and minutes, 24 for hours) |

## 9 LITERATURE COMPARISON: KNOWN VERSUS NEW

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*Why read this: this section separates what already existed in the mathematical literature from what this work adds.*

**Already known:** the Frobenius problem (largest non-representable number), counting multiple representations, positional systems (sexagesimal, decimal, binary), and the digital root as a residue mod 9.

**New in this work:** the foundation condition ( $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ ) not as a description after the fact but as a design principle beforehand; the ladder structure as a method to generate all representations (not just count them); the Diophantine representation system as a deliberate alternative to positional systems; and the generalization of the digital root principle to any  $(p, q)$  pair with  $p \equiv 1 \pmod{q}$ .

In short: the existing literature describes what happens for given coefficients. This work inverts the question: choose coefficients so that desired properties are guaranteed to arise.

| Aspect                   | Known in literature                                                                                                                       | New in this work                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Frobenius problem        | Classical: largest non-representable number $g(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ for coefficients with $\gcd = 1$ (Sylvester 1884; Ramírez Alfonsín 2005) | Foundation condition ( $c_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{c_2}$ ) as a design principle, not descriptive but prescriptive                                                     |
| Multiple representations | $g(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ : largest number with exactly $j$ representations (Beck, Gessel & Komatsu 2001)                                      | Ladder structure $A_k = A_0 + k \cdot c_2$ as a deterministic generator method, not just counting                                                              |
| Positional systems       | Sexagesimal, decimal, binary: unique representation via carry and overflow                                                                | Diophantine representation system as a deliberate alternative to positional systems                                                                            |
| Modular arithmetic       | $N \equiv A \pmod{q}$ as a residue class property                                                                                         | Global mod operation $A_0 = N \pmod{c_2}$ as a structure-determining axiom                                                                                     |
| Canonical number systems | Studied in algebraic number theory (Kovács & Pethő 1991; Scheicher & Thuswaldner 2002)                                                    | Design conditions for optimal denomination systems, explicit coupling to currency design (Euro, Dollar)                                                        |
| Digital root             | $10 \equiv 1 \pmod{9} = \text{digital sum} = N \pmod{9}$                                                                                  | $19 \equiv 1 \pmod{9}$ , $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ as a generalized principle: every $(p, q)$ with $p \equiv 1 \pmod{q}$ generates a digital-root-like structure |

**Core distinction:** the literature describes what happens with given coefficients (Frobenius number, number of representations). This work inverts the question: choose coefficients so that desired properties are guaranteed to arise. It is design mathematics rather than analytical mathematics.

## 10 CONCLUSION

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**Theorem 10.1 (Structural Incomparability in Purpose).** The clock  $[3600, 60, 1]$  and the  $(25, 12)$  system are both linear Diophantine representation systems, but they are structurally incomparable in purpose. The clock is canonical (unique representation); the  $(25, 12)$  system is non-canonical (multiple representations). The clock as metaphor (the 12-hour cycle) is comparable with the modular principle of the  $(25, 12)$  system; the clock as structure is not, because it arrives at uniqueness through a different Diophantine mechanism.

### Formulated Analogy

The clock illustrates the principle of cyclic reduction ( $13 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ ), which in the  $(25, 12)$  system is algebraically realized by  $25 \equiv 1 \pmod{12}$ . The clock  $[3600, 60, 1]$  itself is a canonical positional Diophantine system that does not share this principle. It relies instead on a hierarchical divisibility chain with bounded coefficients. The underlying 12-hour cycle forms the intuitive basis for the modular structure, but the structure itself is a separate object.

### Summary in Three Points

1. **Purpose differs.** The  $(25, 12)$  system is designed for optimization and representation counting. The clock is designed for universal uniqueness.
2. **The Diophantine mechanism differs.** The  $(25, 12)$  system uses one global residue relation ( $A_0 = N \pmod{12}$ ) with unbounded coefficients. The clock uses a hierarchical divisibility chain ( $3600 \rightarrow 60 \rightarrow 1$ ) with coefficients bounded by the ratio of adjacent bases.
3. **The absence of Foundation is not a flaw.**  $3600 \equiv 0 \pmod{60}$  is precisely correct for a positional Diophantine system whose purpose is unique representation. Foundation and positional divisibility are two different Diophantine mechanisms, each suited to a different purpose.